

Peer Mentoring in Postsecondary Settings: Experiences at the College of Charleston

By Meghan Trowbridge, Kinsey Carlson, and Edie Cusack

INTRODUCTION

The word “mentor” invokes myriad meanings. At its most basic level, mentoring assumes some type of collaborative relationship between two people. It can be a formal arrangement or an informal partnership. It can be short-lived or longstanding. What qualifies a person to become a mentor may be professional standing, personal knowledge, life experience, or any one of many other characteristics (Crisp & Cruz, 2009).

On college campuses, mentoring has become a popular way of supporting the transition of new students to postsecondary education. Peer mentoring, where current students are matched with new students, can have a significant impact on the ease with which this transition occurs. Many colleges that have programs for students with intellectual disabilities (ID) use peer mentoring extensively. In South Carolina, the College of Charleston (C of C) uses peer mentoring as a fundamental component of its REACH (Realizing Educational and Career Hopes) Program for students with ID (<http://reach.cofc.edu>).

This brief will detail the importance of mentoring in supporting students with ID on the college campus, using strategies from the REACH Program as examples of effective practice.

CONNECTING LITERATURE AND PRACTICE

Within the past four years, South Carolina has witnessed the development of five postsecondary programs for students with ID. The newest program, REACH, launched on C of C’s historic campus in 2009, and began serving students in fall 2010.

REACH mentors are all volunteer C of C students and must commit to meeting with their mentee at least four hours per week. They do not receive any credit or compensation, but many use this experience to build their resumes.

Jacobi (cited in Crisp & Cruz, 2009) wrote that mentoring relationships generally focus on “the growth and accomplishment of an individual, assisting in professional and career development, role modeling, psychological support, and the development of personal and reciprocal relationships.” This is certainly the aim of the mentoring in the REACH Program. In an effort to develop meaningful and collaborative partnerships between mentor and mentee, Campbell-Whatley (2001) notes that it is important to recruit mentors who can complement an individual’s existing context/setting—hence the recruitment of traditional C of C students to mentor REACH students.

In order to ensure that appropriate supports were in place for the incoming REACH freshmen, staff at C of C recruited peer mentors from the student body to help with the transition. The director of the REACH Program, Edie Cusack, stated, “Students are figuring out their new normal during the first few weeks of school, so we needed to be prepared to support them.” But how did the REACH program create these supports?

Step 1: Recruiting Potential Mentors

REACH Program staff sent out emails to faculty and other college employees asking for recommendations of students who would be good mentors. Five categories of mentors were called for: Housemate, Pre-Teacher, De-Briefer, Tutor, and Social Mentor.

Being specific about the competencies that the mentor would need helped the college faculty and staff nominate students who exhibited those skills. For example, a student who could stand up in front of a classroom to teach a small group of students might make a good Pre-Teacher; while someone who could work with a student to summarize material might excel as a De-Briefer.

Searching for mentor candidates using Facebook, Twitter, and the C of C website proved profitable. REACH Program staff also networked with colleagues who already used mentors in their programs, and partnered with the Office of Excellence in Peer Education (OEPE). The director of OEPE teaches a class on how to be a good peer mentor for typically enrolled C of C students, so it was natural to develop a relationship with OEPE and use the recruiting tools that already existed on campus to identify potential peer mentors.

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Step 2: Screening Potential Peer Mentors

Once a mentor expressed interest in working with the REACH Program, they were sent an application to gather information about their interests, areas of study, hobbies, likes, dislikes, and schedule. This information was used to make a good match with a mentee. The REACH application does not ask potential mentors to provide their GPA. REACH staff have noticed that students who may not be doing well academically improved their grades after their work as a REACH peer mentor.

The mentors are hand-selected by the program director after an interview process. Once selected, mentors are required to participate in a formal training in August.

Before the training, mentors are asked to participate in “Move-in Weekend” with the incoming students. The REACH Program coordinates a potluck dinner after the heavy lifting is done so everyone can socialize and meet in a relaxed setting.

Step 3: Mentor Training

The one-day formal training session (approximately 5 hours) provides a program overview and clarification of mentoring roles. The training also addresses what to expect as a REACH mentor; the matching process, and self-determination.

This initial training gives new mentors an opportunity to meet others who will be working with the REACH students. Mentors are encouraged to ask questions and dispel certain stereotypes. They are also introduced to the support network that will be there for them during their involvement with the REACH Program.

During the training, mentors and staff discuss the matching process. Even though two students appear to be a match on paper, they may not click with one another in person. Mentors often feel that they have to like a person with a disability but are quickly taught to take the disability out of the equation and focus on the person. Some people just don’t get along, and that is okay. When this occurs, the college staff look for another good match for both the mentor and mentee.

Incoming mentors always seem to ask the same question about their mentee: “What can ____ do?” Cusack says, “I tell them to insert another minority/marginalized group into the sentence and then repeat the question. It provides a new perspective and seems to make the point.”

In conjunction with the adult learning literature, the REACH mentor training is experiential. It provides mentors with a variety of disability-awareness and self-determination activities. In one activity, a mentor pulls a slip of paper with a disability written on it. The student must then role-play having this disability during an exercise that involves group communication.

“During the last training, a student asked me if she could ‘suspend her disability’ while we finished the activity, and I used that opportunity to educate the group on the fact that the REACH students cannot ‘suspend’ their disabilities during daily life,” Cusack stated. “Most of the students chose to sit quietly and not participate in the group activity so that they did not have to show their disability.” This illustrates to the mentors just how isolating having a disability can be for students, and how important their role is in the life of a student with ID on campus.

Step 4: Mentoring with Support from the REACH Program

In collaboration with the Center for Disability Resources, the REACH Program offers ongoing training to REACH mentors over the course of the school year. Mentors receive weekly emails about campus activities to make it easier for them to get involved in campus activities with their REACH mentees. Some REACH group activities are scheduled early in the fall semester to make everyone feel more comfortable when meeting new people. These more structured group opportunities taper off during the semester as students get to know each other better and can coordinate their own individual activities.

REACH mentors are asked to keep a journal about their experiences. They are encouraged to explore their fears, expectations, feelings about disability, and positive and negative situations that arise. REACH staffers review the journals, which often reflect a metamorphosis from mentor to friend. The journals are collected at all semester breaks

and trainings and are reviewed during monthly meetings. REACH staffers also use the journals to structure new training sessions.

The REACH director and mentors meet monthly to discuss any concerns, issues, and celebrations. The mentors also have their own secure blog, which is used for collaborative problem-solving. The blog also facilitates discussion around a specific topic each month to stimulate critical thinking about disability and mentoring issues.

FINAL THOUGHTS

Developing peer mentoring at a college is not easy, but it is a vital part of postsecondary education. There are many considerations for developing and implementing a mentoring program. Both the mentor and mentee need to understand their own role as well as the other person's role, and everyone must be clear on the program's policies, boundaries, and expectations (Sword & Hill, 2002).

When the mentoring program's target population is people with disabilities, inclusion and accommodations must also be addressed. The program should provide disability-related information to the mentors and should have a protocol for how to deal with the disclosure of a disability.

Programs should also help mentors become comfortable with acknowledging the specific needs of their mentee while also recognizing their abilities and setting appropriate expectations for success (Sword & Hill, 2002). Daughtry, Abels, and Gibson (2009) add a few suggestions for developing effective mentoring relationships with people with disabilities: using person-first language, treating adults as adults, using active listening skills and asking for clarification when necessary, being patient and empathetic, and respecting boundaries.

The process of creating a mentoring program for students with disabilities is ongoing and ever-evolving. One set system will not necessarily meet the needs of each individual student in the program, so staff must be willing to adapt to accommodate different personalities and situations.

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ABOUT THE AUTHORS

Meghan Trowbridge is the Assistant Director of the Center for Disability Resources at the University of South Carolina School of Medicine.

Kinsey Carlson is the Special Projects Coordinator at the Center for Disability Resources at the University of South Carolina School of Medicine.

Edie Cusack is Director of the REACH Program at the College of Charleston.

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